Blues for an Alabama Sky: Themes

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

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Updated on 14 January 2026

The highest level of marks in exams are often linked to answers that demonstrate critical thinking around ideas and themes. Exploring the themes of a text in relation to the question being asked will help to increase the examiner's confidence in your ability to write assuredly about the text, and the writer's intentions behind their choices.

Below are some of the themes that could be explored in Blues for an Alabama Sky. This list is not exhaustive, and you are encouraged to identify other themes or ideas within the text:

- Dreams and escapism
- Decline of the Harlem Renaissance
- Identity

Dreams and escapism

Pearl Cleage shows the characters in Blues for an Alabama Sky using their dreams and hopes to escape the harsh reality they live in. This is a constant throughout the play, with many characters looking to transform their lives with ideas, hopes and plans. In the end, dreams are a saviour to some, but condemn others.

Knowledge and evidence:

- From the very start, and throughout the play, Cleage presents the idea of moving to Paris as the dream that keeps Guy, and to a lesser extent Angel, going through hard times:
  - Guy is almost numb to the surrounding hardship, continuing to see Paris as the goal to work towards
  - When he and Angel lose their jobs, Guy is largely unconcerned as he believes he will be able to escape

Stuck on something?
Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.
Got it

Harlem and poverty:
    - As a costume designer, Paris represents the pinnacle of artistic expression in fashion
    - It also symbolises endless glamour, to suit the flamboyant lifestyle Guy tries to lead, even when harm comes from it

- Guy and Delia have clear dreams, and Angel and Sam are supporting characters in their respective plans:
    - Sam is attracted to Delia, and helps her get her clinic going, and then finds a new location when it is burned down
    - On the other hand, Angel has little agency in helping Guy to fulfil his dream
    - Guy is also happy to pay her way, and buys her a ticket to Paris when he gets the job

- Delia's dream is more grounded:
    - That her and Sam pursue this dream, while Guy and Angel have Paris as theirs, represents differences in the characters
    - Delia and Sam are more grounded and relatable characters, and the dream of a family clinic is more fitting for them
    - Angel and Guy are loud and dramatic, and Paris suits that

- For the audience, Paris seems quite far-fetched:
    - From the audience's limited perspective, we don't know if Josephine really wants him to come, and whether Guy is being realistic
    - Angel also gives the impression that she doesn't believe it will happen

- It is ironic that the two who lead the dreams are the two who are able to escape:
    - Arguably, it is their support of those dreams, and how they are carried along by them, that lead to Sam and Angel as the tragic figures in the end
    - Sam is killed by Leland for performing the abortion on Angel and being a man supportive of a woman's reproductive **autonomy**
    - Angel tries to use Paris to escape Leland and the prospect of a quiet, family life in Harlem with him
    - In doing so, she ends up contributing to the events of Sam's death and is therefore unable to go with Guy

- Angel and Guy also drink often, using alcohol to escape their situation

What is Cleage's intention?

- Cleage shows that the Harlem Renaissance is over, and with the Depression tightening its grip, people want to escape:
    - It also highlights how the gap between the idealism of Harlem and the lived experience
    - Culturally, it is still lively and exciting, but the economic hardship now has people dreaming of escape or change
    - Angel and Guy want freedom, while the **pragmatic** Delia and Sam are looking to improve Harlem,

Help me understand

will achieve their dreams

- Cleage explores how ambition can be both empowering and dangerous:
  - Guy's dream gives him purpose, while Angel's desire for security means she clings on to anything she can
  - Angel makes destructive choices in desperation
  - Cleage uses these dreams to show us the strengths and flaws of her characters

- Mostly, the dreams are used to show the dangers of escapism as a coping mechanism:
  - If Paris had not worked out for Guy, he and Angel would have been homeless
  - Their eviction notice days before he gets the letter inviting him to France shows how close they were to disaster
  - All the characters manage their pain by escaping to their dreams
  - Cleage consistently presents Leland as oppositional to Angel and the life of her and her friends, but shows Angel's insecurity and instability in having her turn her back on it so easily

Decline of the Harlem Renaissance

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Cleage frames Harlem as a community whose golden age is beginning to slip away, with the characters feeling the constraints around them. Delia and Sam fight growing conservatism, while the economic struggles bite at Angel and Guy as much as the retreating artistic freedom.

Knowledge and evidence:

- Guy and Angel both lose their jobs and start to struggle for money:
  - Both pick up work where they can, but far from what they want to be doing
  - They are quickly under the threat of eviction, and would possibly have been out on the streets if the Paris move had not materialised

- Angel, an experienced singer, and Guy, whose talent is clearly regarded highly enough to be employed in Paris, do not bounce back quickly from unemployment:
  - They are both in professions that would have been central to a thriving Harlem, but those Renaissance

    - Now, the fun is draining away with the money, and Harlem is no longer economically stable nor as culturally exciting
- Delia's work to build the clinic up **symbolises** the changing attitudes to social reform and progressive expressionism:
    - Social reform movements were once thriving in Harlem, but now struggle against backlash and community resistance

- Sam is representative of what Harlem could be:
    - He is educated, progressive, community-focused
    - He manages modern ideas with the traditions and structures of the church

- The friendships of Guy, Angel, Sam and Delia are almost a last stronghold of the Renaissance spirit:
    - They are artistic, progressive, liberal, and they make a chosen family
    - This reflects Harlem's reputation for artistic freedom, queer acceptance, intellectual exchange, and mutual aid
    - This group is what Harlem once offered: possibility, creativity, community

- Economic and social pressures begin to wear on the group:
    - Guy focuses solely on escape to Paris
    - Angel struggles and tries to cling to anyone who can bring stability
    - Delia and Sam have to deal with protests against their family clinic, bringing intense stress

- Leland, an outsider from the South, comes in and contrasts them all:
    - He is deeply traditional, religious, and hostile to the liberalism of Harlem
    - He comes in at the start of the play and the lives of Guy, Angel, Sam and Delia can be seen as starting to suffer from that point

What is Cleage's intention?

- The clinic being burned down is used by Cleage to **symbolise** the destruction of progressive ideas:
    - These ideas defined the Renaissance, so Cleage is showing us how they are fading from prominence

- She may be doing something similar with Leland:
    - Leland is the **antithesis** of these Renaissance ideas
    - His arrival brings the downfall of the group, and his conservative and religious views may represent the downfall of the old Harlem

- She presents Angel as a **symbol** of how Harlem's promise of independence for women has deteriorated:
    - Struggling to maintain work, she looks desperately to Leland, who she isn't particularly fond of, to give her stability and a future

- Cleage also uses the promise of Paris to contrast with the worn-down streets of Harlem:

    - What once was seen as a place of promise and freedom no longer appeals as its spirit changes
- By showing this Renaissance period fading away, Cleage then presents us with the consequences for ordinary Black people in Harlem:
    - The way their group struggles and then is torn apart shows how the shift in attitudes affects their lives
    - She then makes the audience feel their loss, seeing how dramatically they are all affected
    - Sam's death can be seen as **symbolic** of the death of Renaissance Harlem

Identity

From the start, the play shows that each character's identity is shaped, challenged, or limited by the social expectations and pressures surrounding them, especially conservative values, religious influence, reproductive politics, and attitudes towards sexuality.

Knowledge and evidence:

- Angel's identity is always unstable, with a lot of her sense of self based around her relationships with men:
    - She loses her job after confronting the mob man she was dating
    - Struggling for work and money, she feels even more driven into a search for a man to take the burden, which leads her to Leland
    - Leland's seeming stability, rather than his personality, is attractive to Angel
    - She looks to settle with him, as she believes she will be looked after

- Both Guy and Angel are glamorous and loud, but where Guy is proud and confident, Angel uses her bold personality as a front to hide her insecurities:
    - Both are aware that she relies on him

- Guy is an out gay man who is comfortable and confident enough not to hide it:
    - His sexuality is central to his character, expressed in humour and confidence
    - He is emblematic of what Harlem gained from its Renaissance
    - Harlem's artistic environment allows him to express this openly in ways other parts of America would not
    - His confidence occasionally contrasts with the danger he faces when conservative attitudes surface,

    - She is fighting, through her clinic, for more bodily **autonomy** for women
    - Hers is a quieter type of activism

- Delia is shaken by the attack on the clinic:
    - She is just quietly doing what she thinks is right, so isn't quite as primed for opposition as Guy is

- Sam is similar to Delia, his identity as a doctor reflecting science, compassion and professionalism:
    - He believes in the dignity and **autonomy** of women in their medical concerns

- Leland is entirely different to them all:
    - He **symbolises** the growing threat of conservative and religious views shutting down the modern freedoms that had been achieved in Harlem
    - He is also representative of the confidence people like him have, believing their sense of right and wrong springs directly from the Bible

- Leland emphasises sin and morality in the behaviour of the group:
    - He expects Angel to conform to him, and we see that puts pressure on her
    - In the end, he kills Sam because he feels the doctor has acted like a godless sinner
    - Leland breaks the group sense of collective identity, and their chosen family is destroyed by him

What is Cleage's intention?

- Cleage uses the theme of identity to show how personal freedom is shaped, restricted and threatened by social pressures and conflicting views
- With Angel, Cleage shows how dependency can destabilise identity:
    - Her sense of self is closely tied to the men in her life

- Identity is also used to show the changing landscape of Harlem:
    - Guy and Angel are loud and exuberant, which was encouraged in Renaissance Harlem
    - But incidents like Guy being in a fight, and the protests at Delia's clinic, show that Harlem is undergoing change, and losing that expressionism
    - When Guy is beaten for being gay, Cleage shows that the freedom to openly express one's identity now needs to be reined in

- Sam and Delia are used by the author to emphasise grounded, quieter forms of identity and activism:
    - Their calm, rational beliefs in women's **autonomy** and science shows that identity is also shaped by values and moral action, not just personal performance or glamour

- Leland shows Cleage demonstrating the destructive force of conservative morality:
    - In the play, he represents how restrictive conservative religious beliefs can be

    - He is then evidence of how damaging rigid morality can be, as he kills Sam for his sin
- The story examines the emotional consequences of identity under pressure:
    - Cleage demonstrates that when identity is restricted by social and moral forces, individuals may feel isolated, insecure, or forced to compromise their true selves

Sources

Cleage, P. (1999), *Blues for an Alabama Sky* (Dramatists Play Service Inc.)

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